In December 2001 the al-Qaeda-directed ‘Shoe Bomber,’ as Richard Reid is now known, attempted to blow up American Airlines Flight #63 midway between Paris and Miami in December 2001. When interrogated by the FBI after being taken into custody in Boston, where the flight diverted following the failed attempt, Reid told investigators he had acted alone. Yet he was found to lack the technical knowledge necessary to construct the explosive device. Unemployed and with no fixed domicile, Reid also refused to explain how he paid for the ticket for flight #63 or the extensive international airline travel he undertook prior to the failed attack.[200] Clearly there was a support network behind him. Khalid Sheikh Mohammed, the mastermind behind the 9/11 attacks, has since taken responsibility for the operation.[201] Reid is also known to have trained with al-Qaeda in Afghanistan prior to 9/11 and to have fought alongside the Taliban.[202] Moreover, this was not meant to be a one-man operation. A second shoe bomber, Saajid Badat, was slated to blow up a flight from Amsterdam to the US, but pulled out at the last minute.[203] Given these facts, much of the support presumably came from al-Qaeda. However, as the former French magistrate Jean-Louis Bruguière observed, Reid had no historical ties to Paris and therefore no means of subsisting there without a support network.[204]

A French prosecutor asserted that Lashkar’s representative in Paris, Ghulam Mustafa Rama, served as Reid’s ‘compass’ in France.[205] As discussed earlier, it was the investigation into support networks for Reid in France that shed light on Lashkar’s recruiting networks there. Rama was determined to have recruited Hasan El Cheguer and Hakim Mokhfi, and then facilitated their access to a Lashkar training camp. French authorities suspected, but were never able to prove, that Rama met Reid during the latter’s time in Paris, supported him while there and provided him with contact information for a person or persons in Pakistan. Reid traveled to Pakistan in November 2001, not long after this alleged meeting, and is known to have visited Lahore and Karachi. As mentioned, investigators later determined he did not have the technical knowledge to assemble the explosive devices found in his shoes, and it is believed that during this trip Reid had it done for him.[206] This was an al-Qaeda plot, but at the time Reid might have received this technical support the US counter-attack in Afghanistan was in full swing. It is possible he sought assistance from other